

Globalisation has increased interactions between people from different cultural backgrounds, making cross-cultural management an important area of study for modern organisations. The movie *Outsourced* provides a useful illustration of the challenges and opportunities associated with managing employees across national cultures. The film follows Todd Anderson, an American manager who is sent to India to train a newly outsourced call centre after his department in the United States is relocated overseas.

This blog critically analyses the cross-cultural issues presented in the movie by focusing on communication and cultural diversity. The analysis applies Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory and Hall's theory of high-context and low-context communication to explain the misunderstandings and management challenges experienced by Todd and his Indian colleagues. The discussion evaluates how cultural differences influence workplace behaviour, relationships, and organisational performance. The blog concludes by providing recommendations that organisations can implement to improve cross-cultural collaboration and management effectiveness in international business environments.

Key Problems to Analyse

Communication Problems

- Todd struggles to communicate with Indian employees.
- Different accents create customer service issues.
- American and Indian employees interpret messages differently.
- Misunderstandings occur because of indirect versus direct communication styles.

Cultural Diversity Problems

- Todd initially stereotypes Indian culture.
- Employees have different attitudes towards hierarchy.
- Different approaches to work-life balance.
- Cultural misunderstandings reduce team effectiveness.

Communication Analysis Points

Use these ideas:

Hall's High-Context vs Low-Context Theory

- USA = Low-context culture.
- India = More high-context culture.
- Americans prefer direct communication.
- Indians often communicate more indirectly and rely on context.

Example from the Movie

- Todd becomes frustrated because employees do not always give direct answers.
- Workers try to maintain harmony instead of openly disagreeing.

Critical Analysis

- The communication problems are not caused by incompetence.
 - They arise from different cultural assumptions about appropriate communication.
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Cultural Diversity Analysis Points

Hofstede's Dimensions

Power Distance

- India scores higher than the United States.
- Employees show greater respect for authority.
- Staff initially expect Todd to behave as a traditional manager.

Individualism vs Collectivism

- USA is highly individualistic.
- India contains stronger collectivist tendencies.
- Team relationships are more important in India.

Uncertainty Avoidance

- Different responses to change and new procedures.

Critical Analysis

- Todd becomes more effective when he learns to adapt his management style.
 - Cultural diversity eventually becomes a source of strength rather than conflict.
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Recommendations

1. Provide cross-cultural training before international assignments.
 2. Develop cultural intelligence among managers.
 3. Encourage open communication across cultures.
 4. Adapt leadership styles to local cultural expectations.
 5. Establish clear communication protocols for global teams.
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Conclusion Points

- The movie demonstrates the importance of understanding cultural differences.
- Communication and cultural diversity significantly affect organisational performance.
- Cross-cultural theories explain many workplace challenges.
- Successful managers adapt their behaviour rather than expecting others to conform.